just an hour or two before the test and transmitted through a secure network. The narrow window will leave little time for anyone to compromise the system, provided the centres are reliable and well-equipped. That is why the committee pushed for owned infrastructure. "In the 2025 and 2026 test cycles of NEET, most of the test centres were owned by the central or state governments. This is the process which will go on for the 2027 cycle, when we are going to move into CBT," he said.

Professor Aditya Mittal of IIT Delhi, also a member of the Radhakrishnan Committee, says India should build this capacity in schools rather than rent it. "Every district has a Kendriya Vidyalaya, and every Kendriya Vidyalaya can have 100 computer terminals. These terminals can be used during major entrance examinations, and for teaching children for the rest of the year. This is akin to pre-computer-based examinations when schools partnered with the IIT system and served as centres for paper-based examinations."

But CBT is not a magic shield. It did not prevent JEE Main 2021 from being hacked. It is also virtually impossible to have a single CBT session for 2-2.5 million candidates. "We do not have the capacity for 20 lakh candidates," says Subrahmanyam. Multiple sittings mean different candidates answer different question sets of varying difficulty. To ensure fairness, scores must then be normalised, a statistical adjustment the NMC distrusts, though JEE Main already uses it.

The Percentile Predicament

Critics also question NEET's admissions logic. It has no fixed pass mark. A candidate qualifies not by scoring a percentage but by clearing a percentile, a measure of how many candidates you beat, not of marks. "And therein lies the heart of the distortion," says Vineet Joshi, Secretary, Higher Education, who ran the NTA between 2018 and 2023. "Assume that the qualifying score is 50 per cent," he says. "If the exam is of 720 marks, 50 per cent means 360 marks. To get 360, one has to work hard. But when it becomes 50 percentile, half the students will always be eligible, irrespective of their marks. If 24 lakh students sit, 50 percentile means 12 lakh students." That, he adds, "creates a bigger pool, and then one can play with that pool, especially in private institutions" that simply need enough eligible candidates to fill their seats.

Then, there are the monetary stakes. Medicine remains one of India's most lucrative and socially respected professions. For many families, a medical seat is not just an educational opportunity, but a promise of financial security, social status and upward mobility. That makes the incentive to game the system dangerously high. If the expected returns on becoming a doctor runs into crores over a career, spending a few lakhs to buy your way in through a rigged exam is no big deal.

The structure of admissions has now sharpened that incentive. Under the percentile system, a candidate needs only around 140-150 marks to become eligible for a private medical seat by paying the fees. The gap between a government college and a private one can run close to Rs 1 crore. For a family spending Rs 25-30 lakh to manipulate the result and still save far more is a cold, rational calculation.



Dharmendra Pradhan, the Union minister of education, conceded "there was a breach somewhere in the chain of command"

The desperation shows up in the numbers themselves. "In any exam, you would find attendance at 75-80 per cent. In NEET, it is 99 per cent," says NTA director-general Singh. That intensity, he argues, long made cancellation feel impossible, which only emboldened the racketeers. "Scamsters believed that because of the logistics involved, the government and the NTA would refrain from cancelling such a big exam." The first-ever cancellation is meant to flip that calculation.

Ignoring the Doctor's Orders

The cancellation has also revived questions of how far the NTA heeded the Radhakrishnan Committee's 101 recommendations. Of its top recommendations, the NTA and the government acted briskly on the visible, logistical ones—district-level control, Aadhaar biometrics, government-owned centres, AI-enabled CCTV—but ducked the two that mattered the most: spreading the exam across multiple sessions and shifting it to a computer-assisted format.

Radhakrishnan, who also heads the implementation-monitoring committee, clarifies that the first 60 or so recommendations were meant for the 2025 and 2026 cycles and 80 per cent have been carried out. "In 2025, things went very smoothly; there was complete coordination and everything was in place," says Bansal. But even as the 2025 reforms strengthened the logistics chain—centres, transport and exam-day control—it left the upstream paper-setting process largely untouched. Which is where the 2026 leak originated. Now, the arrests have cast a shadow on the previous year. Since some of those now held were allegedly also active in 2025, a reform committee member wonders whether the previous examination was